Moving beyond the orderly if somewhat muddy First Street, the plan shows a city full of oddly aligned winding streets and lanes. It is unlikely that the royal visitor and his entourage undertook a tour of these, but since archaeological details about them help recreate the ambience of movement and habitation, it is worth going beyond what is likely to have been seen. Much narrower than the main street, these side streets and lanes are an odd combination of straight and winding segments.[24] The Second Street, for instance, begins on a somewhat straight alignment that, less than halfway through the city, moves by several feet towards the west, and again after intersecting the Third Street lurches in a wide curve towards the east. As for the lanes, 'they were narrower still, no more in fact than passages between the houses in which two persons would often find it difficult to walk abreast.'[25] A few of these narrow alleys appear to have been meant only for the private use of the houses that flanked them. This was the case with Lane 2 which, towards its western end, was cordoned off by a cross-wall.[26] This meant that people who wanted to cut across from First Street to Second Street could not use Lane 2, which connected them. Instead, they would either have to follow Lane 1 or move north and turn left, on Third Street. So, Lane 2 in effect became a kind of private alleyway.

What makes this mishmash surprising is that the elegant main street had been the city's thoroughfare from earliest times. Practically all the other streets and lanes, the awfully asymmetrical ones, were created later, during the late fourth and early third centuries BCE.[27] One would have expected the later development to have emulated the proportionate and urban good sense of the earlier rather than fallen short of them, so the disfigurations of Taxila's bylanes have disappointed many a modern scholar of those times, especially as images of cities in Mauryan times commonly suggest a reasonable degree of planning. So, for instance, the ideal urban layout as described in the *Arthashastra* is of a city space demarcated by six roads, three running from east to west and three from north to south; this is what